spinning and weaving of cotton. [6] To this day, the Indian subcontinent remains a major exporter of cotton textiles and garments.

Strangely, we have no idea what the Harappans imported. Hardly any object of Mesopotamian origin has been found at Harappan sites. Perhaps they imported consumables like dates and wine but we really do not know. The same can be said about trade with Iran and Central Asia. As already mentioned, archaeologists have found a Harappan outpost in Shortughai on the Afghan–Tajik border. What were they doing there? One intriguing possibility is that they were there to buy horses. The inability to breed good-quality horses would plague India right into the nineteenth century and force Indian rulers to import large numbers from Central Asia and Arabia. Marco Polo would comment on this in the thirteenth century. We will return to this issue later.

WHAT HAPPENED TO INDIA'S FIRST CITIES?

We now know that this civilization did not suddenly appear or disappear. Excavations in Mehrgarh, near Quetta in Balochistan, show the gradual evolution from Neolithic village to an increasingly more sophisticated culture from around 7000 BC. The earliest recognizably Harappan sites date to 3500 BC. This early phase lasts till around 2600 BC. We then enter the Mature phase from 2600 BC to 2000 BC. This is when the great cities were at their height. Note that this is a Bronze Age culture and there is no systematic use of iron. Then, from around 2000 BC we have a steady disintegration that lasts till 1400 BC—what is usually called Late Harappan.

This is a simplified timeline. In reality, cities rose and fell and were sometimes rebuilt on older sites. Some areas flourished when others were in decline. Nonetheless, there are clear signs that the overall civilization was in severe stress after 2000 BC. We see steady deterioration in municipal governance till one by one the great cities are abandoned. What went wrong?

It was once believed that Aryan invasions from Central Asia had caused the collapse of the Indus Valley Civilization. However, there is no sign that